

INDO-PAK BILATERAL TALKS

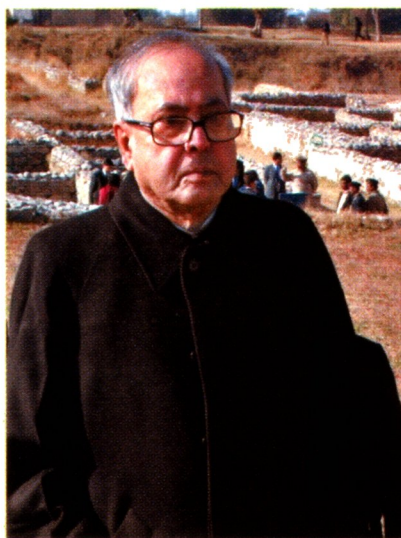
A Question of Trust

Under the shadow of the Jaipur serial bombings, External Affairs Minister Pranab Mukherjee lands in Islamabad on May 20 to kick-start the composite dialogue process between the two countries after a long hiatus with the terror issue expected to dominate the agenda. Mukherjee's visit is expected to provide some momentum to the stalled dialogue process, but progress on vexed issues like Kashmir, Siachen and Sir Creek is not expected any time soon.

The visit comes close on the heels of a major infiltration attempt on the international border, and the violation of the 2003 ceasefire by the Pakistan Army. "We have said that the stopping of cross-border terrorism is a very high priority," remarked Foreign Secretary Shiv Shankar Menon. There will be a joint **IRON HAND: Mukherjee will have to talk tough in Islamabad**

statement but no major announcements are expected during the trip.

This will be the first formal engagement between India and Pakistan since the PPP-led coalition Government came to power in Islamabad in March this year, and the two countries will be looking to



consolidate trade ties which almost doubled in value from Rs 3,846.45 crore in 2005-06 to Rs 7,563.49 crore in 2007. Both sides have exchanged over 100 proposals during the composite dialogue process that was started in 2004, but its progress has been tardy. There are indications, that the new rulers in Islamabad may shelve the limited progress on issues such as Kashmir, Sir Creek through back-channels.

Mukherjee's visit is more ritualistic than substantive and will provide him with a first hand assessment of what is on the mind of the new Pakistani leadership. But the timing may not be opportune because of fissures within the ruling alliance of Pakistan. While Mukherjee will have enough time for diplomatic niceties during the trip as he meets key Pakistani leaders, the national interest will be best served if he does some plain speaking on the terrorism issue, as dialogue with Pakistan will be futile if it is not able to vanquish the spectre of violence and build trust between the two south Asian neighbours.

by Saurabh Shukla

Court—and re-open those cases.

Popular perception is that PPP has become, in the words of Imran Khan, the "A-team of General Musharraf"—replacing the so-called king's party, former ruling party Pakistan Muslim League (Quaid-e-Azam) (PML-Q)—and is doing all it can to protect Musharraf as part of the American-backed deal that brought Benazir back from self-exile. Musharraf, of course, has the most to lose from the restoration of the judges. Not only does he lose face, he faces the threat of his election as president being declared unconstitutional if a pre-November 3 judiciary is restored. His sacking of the judges was almost certainly motivated by this threat. PPP's insistence on retaining current Supreme Court judges—a demand Sharif had

reluctantly agreed to before May 12—is also seen as an attempt to put more Musharraf-friendly judges in Chaudhry's court.

Whether people were surprised at the swiftness of cracks appearing in the coalition or not, there is no doubt that PML-N's pull out has dealt a blow to public perception of the Government. There is no imminent danger of the Government collapsing—PPP does not need too many more parliamentarians

to maintain a simple majority—but if PML-N refuses to budge, PPP may be forced to become closer to pro-Musharraf parties such as Muttahida Qaumi Movement (MQM) and PML-Q, further damaging its credibility. In fact, PPP is in coalition with MQM in Sindh and there are reports of it also wooing a bloc within

PML-Q. But PPP is also hopeful that PML-N will rejoin government once the issue of the judges is settled.

With Sharif out of the federal government, it is unclear how PPP intends to move ahead on the question of restoration. Its constitutional package, for one, would require support from other parties to be acceptable to the public. There is also a danger that a revitalised lawyers' struggle and civil society movement—which may be unwilling to accept compromise solutions—may once again take to the streets, causing problems for PPP, particularly in the populous Punjab where PML-N governs in coalition with PPP. PML-N has already signalled its intent to support such a cause.

Observers feel Sharif's stubbornness is at least partly motivated by his hostility towards Musharraf, who deposed him and sent him into exile. Ironically, the cracks in the coalition may ultimately benefit the one man Sharif would like to see the back of. ■

Zardari has misgivings about restoring the judges without clipping some of their powers.